Key Definitions — Glossary

Core frameworks & concepts · Harvard-referenced course

Definitions of the frameworks, tools and models taught across the ten units. Each entry is written in original English and cross-referenced to its unit. Full sources appear in the Academic References document.

2×2 Prioritisation Matrix UNIT 7

A 2×2 matrix ranks options along two chosen dimensions — commonly impact and effort — producing four quadrants (e.g. quick wins, big bets, fill-ins, time-sinks). It converts a long, flat list of ideas into a visual prioritisation everyone can see and debate.

5 Whys UNIT 4

5 Whys is a root-cause technique in which you ask 'why?' repeatedly — conventionally about five times — each answer forming the basis of the next question, until you move past symptoms to an underlying, addressable cause. The number five is a rule of thumb, not a law.

6-3-5 Brainwriting UNIT 2

6-3-5 Brainwriting is a structured silent-ideation method: six participants each write three ideas on a sheet, then pass it on; over five rounds each sheet accumulates and builds on prior ideas. In theory it yields up to 108 ideas in about 30 minutes, free of the loudest-voice bias of spoken brainstorming.

A/B Testing UNIT 9

A/B testing is a controlled online experiment that randomly shows variant A or B to comparable groups of real users and measures which performs better on a defined metric. Randomisation lets teams attribute the difference to the change itself, not to opinion or chance.

AEIOU Framework UNIT 5

AEIOU is a coding scheme for organising field observations across five lenses: Activities (goal-directed actions), Environments (the setting), Interactions (between people and systems), Objects (artefacts in use) and Users (the people themselves). It structures raw ethnographic data into analysable categories.

Blue Ocean / ERRC Grid UNIT 7

Blue Ocean Strategy urges firms to stop competing in crowded 'red oceans' and create uncontested 'blue oceans' through value innovation — pursuing differentiation and low cost at once. The ERRC grid operationalises this: which factors to Eliminate, Reduce, Raise and Create relative to the industry.

Brainstorming UNIT 7

Brainstorming is group idea-generation governed by four rules: defer judgement, strive for quantity, build on the ideas of others and encourage wild ideas. Separating generation from evaluation lets a group produce more and more original options than criticism-as-you-go allows.

Componential Model of Creativity UNIT 1

Amabile's componential model proposes that individual creativity is the product of three components: domain-relevant skills (expertise and knowledge), creativity-relevant processes (cognitive styles and idea-generation techniques) and task motivation — with intrinsic motivation the decisive multiplier. A surrounding organisational component (the social environment) either fuels or suppresses the three.

Context Mapping UNIT 6

Context Mapping visualises the broader system around a problem — stakeholders, trends, constraints, competitors and forces — so the team designs with, rather than against, its environment. It widens the frame from the user to the ecosystem they inhabit.

Critical Items Diagram UNIT 6

A Critical Items Diagram plots the assumptions behind a concept on two axes — how critical each is to success and how uncertain it is — so the team can prioritise testing the assumptions that are both essential and unknown. It directs scarce validation effort where risk is highest.

Customer Journey Map UNIT 5

A Customer Journey Map visualises the end-to-end experience of a user achieving a goal — the sequence of stages and touchpoints, what they do at each, and the emotional highs and lows along the way. It exposes pain points and moments of opportunity across the whole experience, not a single screen.

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DT Workshop Design UNIT 10

DT Workshop Design is the craft of planning and running a design-thinking workshop: a clear objective, the right participants, a timed sequence of activities that move a group through divergent and convergent work, and a defined decision or output the session must produce.

Define Success UNIT 10

Define Success is the practice of agreeing, before building, the concrete criteria and metrics by which a solution will be judged — user, business and feasibility outcomes. It creates a shared target so teams can later tell whether they have actually succeeded.

Desirability–Feasibility–Viability UNIT 3

Every sustainable innovation must sit at the overlap of three lenses: Desirability (do people want it?), Feasibility (can we build it technically and operationally?) and Viability (can it sustain a business?). Design thinking deliberately starts from desirability, then reconciles the other two.

Divergent–Convergent Thinking UNIT 1

Creative work alternates between two modes: divergent thinking, which generates many varied options from a single starting point, and convergent thinking, which analyses, evaluates and narrows to the best. Keeping the two separate protects fragile early ideas from premature judgement.

Dot Voting UNIT 2

Dot voting (dotmocracy) is a simple prioritisation technique: each participant is given a fixed number of adhesive dots (or marks) and places them on the options they most support. The distribution of dots gives a quick, visible read of collective preference.

Double Diamond UNIT 3

The Double Diamond depicts design as two linked diamonds: the first (Discover → Define) explores then frames the problem; the second (Develop → Deliver) explores then delivers the solution. Each diamond widens (divergent) before it narrows (convergent), stressing that problem and solution each need exploration.

Empathy Map UNIT 5

An Empathy Map is a canvas that captures what a user says, thinks, does and feels (often with pains and gains), building a shared, externalised picture of their experience. It surfaces gaps — for example, where what a user says diverges from what they truly feel.

Feedback Capture Grid UNIT 9

A Feedback Capture Grid is a 2×2 template for structuring reactions to a prototype into four quadrants: things the reviewer liked, criticisms or wishes, questions raised, and new ideas sparked. It forces specific, balanced feedback instead of vague praise.

How Might We (HMW) UNIT 6

'How Might We…' questions reframe a point-of-view problem as an invitation to ideate. The phrasing is deliberate: How assumes solutions exist, Might gives permission to fail, and We makes it collaborative. Good HMWs are neither too broad nor too narrow.

Implementation Roadmap UNIT 10

An Implementation Roadmap is a phased plan for embedding a design or change into an organisation — sequencing pilots, visible early wins, capability-building and scaling — with owners, milestones and metrics. It turns a validated concept into an adoption journey.

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) UNIT 8

An MVP is the smallest, cheapest version of a product that lets a team begin the build–measure–learn loop with real users and validated learning. It is not a smaller product but a learning device: the least you can build to test your riskiest assumption.

Paper / Low-fi Prototype UNIT 8

A paper or low-fidelity prototype is a rough, hand-made representation of an interface or experience — sketches, paper screens, cardboard mock-ups — built in minutes to test flow and concept before any investment in visuals or code. Its crudeness invites honest critique.

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Peers-Observing-Peers UNIT 5

Peers-Observing-Peers is a research method in which members of a target community observe and document each other's behaviour, capturing candid, in-context actions that outsiders or self-reports would miss. It leverages insider access and trust.

Persona / User Profile UNIT 5

A persona is a fictional but evidence-based character that represents a key user segment — with goals, behaviours, context, frustrations and a name and face. It gives an abstract 'user' a concrete identity teams can design for and refer to consistently.

Point of View (PoV) Statement UNIT 6

A Point of View statement crystallises empathy research into one actionable problem framing, classically '[user] needs [need] because [surprising insight]'. It commits the team to a specific, human, insight-driven problem before ideation begins.

Reframing Matrix UNIT 4

The Reframing Matrix examines a single problem from four different perspectives — classically the '4 Ps': Product, Planning, Potential and People, or the distinct professional viewpoints of, say, a marketer, engineer, financier and customer. Each frame surfaces options the default frame hides.

SCAMPER UNIT 1

SCAMPER is a checklist of seven idea-triggering verbs applied to an existing product, service or process to force new variations: Substitute, Combine, Adapt, Modify (magnify/minify), Put to other use, Eliminate and Reverse. Each prompt deliberately disrupts assumptions to generate fresh options.

Service Blueprint UNIT 8

A Service Blueprint maps a service end-to-end across layers: customer actions, front-stage (visible) employee actions, back-stage (invisible) actions, and supporting processes, separated by a 'line of visibility'. It reveals how the whole system must work to deliver the customer experience.

Six Thinking Hats UNIT 2

Six Thinking Hats is a parallel-thinking method in which a group deliberately adopts one 'hat' — one mode of thinking — at a time: White (facts), Red (feelings), Black (caution), Yellow (optimism), Green (creativity) and Blue (process control). Everyone thinks in the same mode simultaneously, avoiding adversarial argument.

Solution Interview UNIT 9

A Solution Interview presents a proposed solution to a user who has the target problem and probes whether it genuinely addresses their need, what they would pay or change, and where it falls short. It validates problem–solution fit before scaling.

Storytelling UNIT 6

Design storytelling casts research findings and concepts as a narrative — a protagonist (the user), a tension (their unmet need) and a resolution (the design). Narrative makes abstract insight vivid, memorable and persuasive to stakeholders and teammates alike.

The 4 P's of Creativity UNIT 1

The 4 P's framework holds that every creative phenomenon can be analysed through four interacting strands: the creative Person (traits, motivation, ability), the Process (the mental operations of creating), the Press (the environment or climate that encourages or suppresses creativity) and the Product (the tangible novel, useful outcome). Studying only one strand gives a partial picture of creativity (Rhodes, 1961).

Trend Analysis UNIT 5

Trend Analysis systematically scans social, technological, economic, environmental and political shifts to anticipate how user needs and contexts will change. It grounds design decisions in where the world is heading, not only where users are today.

Usability Testing UNIT 9

Usability testing observes representative users attempting realistic tasks with a prototype or product, recording where they succeed, hesitate or fail. It measures whether the design actually works for people, rather than whether they say they like it.

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Vision Cone UNIT 6

The Vision Cone (futures cone) projects forward from the present into widening bands of probable, plausible, possible and preferable futures. It helps teams distinguish the future they expect from the one they want, and design toward the latter.

Wizard of Oz Prototype UNIT 8

In a Wizard of Oz prototype, users interact with what looks like an automated system while a human secretly performs the back-end functions. It tests desirability and the experience of a capability before that capability is actually built.

Worst Possible Idea UNIT 7

Worst Possible Idea is a reverse-brainstorming technique: the group deliberately generates the worst solutions to a problem, then flips each into its opposite or extracts the useful kernel. Removing the pressure to be good unlocks fluency and surfaces surprising strong ideas.

d.school 5-Stage Model UNIT 3

The d.school model organises human-centred design into five non-linear modes: Empathise (understand users), Define (frame the right problem), Ideate (generate options), Prototype (make ideas tangible) and Test (learn from users). Teams loop back freely rather than march straight through.